MLA 9 Citation Snapshot for Musicians

ISHCMC Music | Mr Wisdom | Every pattern from Citation Island on one handout

Every example here follows MLA 9, the 9th edition of the MLA Handbook. The colours match the pieces in the Citation Island game.

Author Title (small thing) Container (big thing) Publisher or place Date URL or access date Other details

1. The two jobs of citing

Every source you use is cited twice: once in your Works Cited list at the end, and once in the text where you use it.

Job	Where it goes	What it looks like
Works Cited entry	A list at the end of your work	Full details of the source
In-text citation	In your sentence, right after the quote or idea	(Nettl 57)

2. Setting up the Works Cited page

- Start a new page at the end, titled Works Cited, centred and not bold.
- Put entries in alphabetical order by their first word, usually the author's last name. Ignore A, An and The.
- Double-space everything and use a hanging indent: the first line starts at the margin, the next lines move in 1.27 cm (half an inch).
- Flip only the first author's name: Last Name, First Name.
- Put containers (book, album, journal, website, score) in *italics*. Put small things inside them (song, article, web page, video) in “quotation marks”.
- Write dates as Day Month Year and shorten long months: Jan., Feb., Mar., Apr., Aug., Sept., Oct., Nov., Dec. May, June and July stay whole.

3. Citing a website, step by step

Work down the web page and collect each piece in this order. Skip any piece the page does not have.

1 **Author.** A person: Last Name, First Name. An organisation: its name. No author, or the author has the same name as the website? Skip this step.

2 **Page title,** in “quotation marks”.

3 **Website name,** in *italics*.

4 **Publisher,** only if it is different from the website name. Look in the footer or the About page.

5 **Date** the page was published or updated, as Day Month Year: 3 Feb. 2025.

6 **URL,** copied from the address bar, without https://.

7 **Access date,** written as Accessed 9 Nov. 2026. See the table below.

Lee, Hannah. “Five Ways to Practise Scales.” *Example Music Blog*, Example Media Group, 3 Feb. 2025, www.example.com/practise-scales.

A made-up example to show the shape. In-text: (Lee). With no author, use a short title: (“Five Ways”).

Level	When to add the access date
Grades 6 to 8 (MYP 1 to 3)	Only when the page shows no date of its own
Grades 9 to 10 (MYP 4 to 5)	Only when the page shows no date of its own (optional in MLA 9)
Grades 11 to 12 (IB Diploma)	Always, for every online source in IB work

4. Works Cited formats

Book (one author)

Pattern: Last Name, First Name. *Title of Book*. Edition, Publisher, Year.

Paul, Roger. *IB Music Revision Guide*. 3rd ed., Anthem Press, 2018.

MLA 9 leaves out the city of publication.

Book (two authors)

Pattern: Flip the first author only.

Nettl, Bruno, and Timothy Rommen. *Excursions in World Music*. 7th ed., Routledge, 2017.

Book (three or more authors)

Pattern: Name the first author, then et al.

Burkholder, J. Peter, et al. *A History of Western Music*. 10th ed., W. W. Norton, 2019.

Online encyclopedia

Pattern: Author. “Entry Title.” *Encyclopedia Name*, Date, URL.

Malm, William P. “Japanese Music.” *Encyclopedia Britannica*, 2015, www.britannica.com/art/Japanese-music.

Leave out the publisher when it has the same name as the website.

Database article (JSTOR, ProQuest)

Pattern: Author. “Article.” *Journal*, vol., no., Year, pages. *Database*, DOI or URL.

Langhamer, Claire. “Love and Courtship in Mid-Twentieth-Century England.” *Historical Journal*, vol. 50, no. 1, 2007, pp. 173-96. *ProQuest*, https://doi.org/10.1017/S0018246X06005966.

Write a DOI as a full link starting https://doi.org/.

Song (Spotify or Apple Music)

Pattern: Artist. “Song.” *Album*, Record Label, Year. *Platform*, URL.

Morris, Rae. “Skin.” *Unguarded*, Atlantic Records, 2015. *Spotify*, open.spotify.com/track/0OPES3Tw5r86O6fudK8gxi.

Flip a solo artist's name. Never flip a band name, such as Arctic Monkeys.

Album

Pattern: Artist. *Album Title*. Record Label, Year.

Morris, Rae. *Unguarded*. Atlantic Records, 2015.

Liner notes

Pattern: Writer of the notes. Liner notes. *Album Title*, by Artist, Record Label, Year.

YouTube (creator is not the uploader)

Pattern: Author. “Video.” *YouTube*, uploaded by Name, Date, URL.

McGonigal, Jane. “Gaming and Productivity.” *YouTube*, uploaded by Big Think, 3 July 2012, www.youtube.com/watch?v=mkdzy9bWW3E.

YouTube (creator is the uploader)

Pattern: Channel. “Video.” *YouTube*, Date, URL. Leave out “uploaded by”.

Crazy Russian Hacker. “8 Hot Dog Gadgets put to the Test.” *YouTube*, 6 June 2016, www.youtube.com/watch?v=WBlpjSEtELs.

Live concert

Pattern: Performer. *Title of Performance*. Venue, City, Date.

ISHCMC Music Department. *Secondary Winter Recital 2026*. Secondary Theatre, ISHCMC, Ho Chi Minh City, 16 Dec. 2026.

If you focus on one performer or composer, start with their name instead.

Musical score

Pattern: Composer. *Title of Score*. Edited by Name, Publisher, Year.

Bach, Johann Sebastian. *Six Suites for Violoncello Solo*. Edited by Bettina Schwemer and Douglas Woodfull-Harris, Bärenreiter, 2000.

For an online score, add the website in italics and the URL at the end.

Goes in *italics*	Goes in “quotation marks”
The container: book, album, journal, score, website (YouTube, Spotify, ProQuest)	The small thing inside it: song, article, entry, web page, video

5. In-text citations

Put the first word of the Works Cited entry (usually the author's last name) and the page number in brackets, with no comma between them.

Source	In brackets
One author	(Nettl 57)
Two authors	(Nettl and Rommen 57)
Three or more authors	(Burkholder et al. 214)
No author	(“How Gamelan Tuning Works”)
No page numbers	(Malm)
Song or video	(McGonigal 00:02:15-00:02:45)

Type	How to do it	Example
Direct quote	Copy the words exactly, in “double quotation marks”, then cite.	“music often has functional purposes” (Nettl 57)
Indirect quote	A quote your source quoted. Single marks inside double marks, and qtd. in.	“music is ‘often used as expression’” (qtd. in Nettl 78-79)
Paraphrase	Your own words. No quotation marks, but you still cite.	... are often limited because they must be easy to carry (Nettl 62).
Long quote	Over four lines: new line, indent 1.27 cm, no quotation marks, citation after the final full stop.	... final sentence of the quote. (Nettl 62)

These quotations show the format only. Check the real page before you quote.

6. Extra rules for IB Diploma students (Grades 11 to 12)

In IB work, cite everything you did not create yourself: words, ideas, images, recordings, scores, data and output from AI tools.

- Use one citation style, such as MLA 9, all the way through each piece of work.
- Add an access date to every online source.
- Label each image, chart or score excerpt as Fig. 1, Fig. 2 and so on, give it a caption that names the source, and list the source in your Works Cited.
- Cite AI tools only where your teacher allows them, and say how you used them.

Pattern: “Your prompt” prompt. *Name of AI Tool*, version, Company, Date, URL.

> “Explain what a ground bass is in Baroque music” prompt. *ChatGPT*, GPT-4o version, OpenAI, 12 Oct. 2026, chatgpt.com.

A made-up example. Follow the school's academic integrity policy and ask your supervisor when you are unsure.

7. Final check before you submit

- ☐ Every quote and paraphrase has an in-text citation.
- ☐ Every in-text citation matches an entry in my Works Cited list.
- ☐ My Works Cited page is double-spaced, uses a hanging indent and is in alphabetical order.
- ☐ The first author's name is flipped: Last Name, First Name.
- ☐ Containers are in italics; small things are in “quotation marks”.
- ☐ Books have no city of publication.
- ☐ DOIs start with https://doi.org/ and long months are shortened (24 Apr. 2020).
- ☐ Songs and videos use timestamps instead of page numbers.
- ☐ Quotes inside quotes use ‘single quotation marks’ and qtd. in.
- ☐ IB students: every online source has an access date.